



THE MORNING KICKOFF

📍 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Spain are through — tonight England–Argentina decide who joins them

🌟 Spain 2–0 France — Oyarzabal's penalty and Porro send Spain to the final

📺 Tonight: England–Argentina in Atlanta, 21:00 — the winner meets Spain Sunday

★ Crystal Ball: our France call missed — record now 5 from 8. Tonight: England 2–1

⚡ SEMI-FINAL 1 · FRANCE 0–2 SPAIN

THE WALL WINS. SPAIN SILENCE FRANCE.

The record defence didn't crack — it closed. Oyarzabal converted the penalty Yamal won off Digne, Pedro Porro finished a give-and-go with Olmo, and the tournament's most feared attack was reduced to 0.26 expected goals and a single shot on target. Spain are in their first World Cup final since they won it in 2010 — and tonight, England and Argentina decide who gets to try to stop them.



Mikel Oyarzabal — ice from the spot in the 22nd minute, his fifth goal of the tournament

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ The Crystal Ball called France 2–1; Spain answered 2–0. The record drops to 5 winners from 8 — and tonight it swings again: England 2–1 is the call.
- ⚡ Mbappé's night: 34 touches, three shots, none on target, one yellow — and a third-place match on Saturday instead of a final. Saliba went off with a non-contact injury.
- 📅 Tonight, 21:00 our time in Atlanta: England–Argentina, their first World Cup meeting since 2002. Kalshi has it at England 36, Tie 34, Argentina 32 — \$1.34m traded.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2 France 0–2 Spain — the full report: the penalty, Porro, and the 0.26 xG suffocation
- P.3 Tonight previewed: England–Argentina, plus the history books from 1966 to 2002
- P.4 The Crystal Ball: England 2–1 — probabilities, factors, and the live market
- P.5 Golden Boot: Messi can break the tie tonight; Oyarzabal joins the chase on 5
- P.6 The road to the final: Spain wait at MetLife — bracket, third place, the week

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)



England – Argentina



21:00

FULL PREVIEWS PAGE 3 →

⚡ STATEMENT

📍 AT&T Stadium, Dallas



France

0 – 2

FULL TIME

Spain



⊗ Oyarzabal 22' · penalty
⊗ Porro 58' · give-and-go with Olmo

On Bastille Day, the wall held its parade. Spain absorbed France's opening surge, allowed 0.04 expected goals in the entire first half, and struck through the move that has defined their tournament: Yamal running at a full-back until something breaks. Digne lunged, the referee pointed, and Oyarzabal — ice-cold from the spot — put Spain ahead in the 22nd minute.

The second was pure Spain: Porro exchanged passes with Olmo at the edge of the box and side-footed past Maignan in the 58th. Mbappé, shadowed everywhere by Cucurella and company, finished with 34 touches, no shot on target and a yellow card for his frustration. Simón, when needed, swept and saved. Spain's first final since 2010; France's perfect tournament ends in silence.

MATCH TIMELINE

● Spain above · ● France below



★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Lamine Yamal

Drew the penalty, terrorised Digne all evening, and was denied a goal of his own only by the offside flag. Three knockouts against France in two years — three Spanish wins he authored.



Kylian Mbappé

Eight goals coming in, none going out. Smothered by the best defence he has faced, his World Cup ends with a yellow card and a third-place match on Saturday.

⚡ France were held to 0.26 expected goals and a single shot on target — the perfect team's worst attacking night by a distance

⚽ The opener came when Yamal's run drew the foul from Digne — Oyarzabal buried the penalty in the 22nd

⊗ France burned all their substitutes by the 72nd minute chasing the game; Saliba had gone off injured before half-time

→ **WHAT IT MEANS** Spain go to MetLife on Sunday chasing a second star. France drop to Saturday's third-place match in Miami against tonight's loser.

SF2 · TONIGHT · ATLANTA



England



Argentina



-  21:00
-  22:00
-  00:30 +1
-  15:00
-  13:00

Kick-off 3:00 PM ET at the stadium Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta

The Hand of God, Beckham's red, Beckham's penalty — and now, for the first time, a World Cup semi-final between them. It is their first World Cup meeting since 2002, and the prize is Spain at MetLife. Both squads are healthy: Rice has fully recovered, both XIs are expected unchanged in shape. Both also played 120 minutes on Saturday — the last half-hour tonight may belong to whoever recovered better. The market is the closest of the tournament: England 36, the tie 34, Argentina 32.

- 👁 **Bellingham against Messi — four knockout goals versus the man two wins from back-to-back titles**
- 👁 **Kane on 5: the Golden Boot leaders are stuck on 8, and neither plays a final unless their team gets there first**
- 👁 **Set pieces — with legs heavy from Saturday's extra time, one dead ball could decide the whole night**
- 👁 **It's the first England–Argentina semi-final ever — all five World Cup meetings before tonight came in the groups, last 16 or quarters**



KEY MAN · ARGENTINA

Lionel Messi

At 39, two games from retaining the World Cup — something no one has done since Brazil in 1962. England are the one great rival he has never beaten on this stage.



ENGLAND–ARGENTINA: THE HISTORY BOOKS

Sixty years of grudge matches — tonight is the first since 2002

-  **England** 3 – 1 **Argentina**  Chile 62 · group
-  **England** 1 – 0 **Argentina**  1966 QF · Rattín sent off
-  **Argentina** 2 – 1 **England**  Mexico 86 · Hand of God
-  **Argentina** 2 – 2 **England**  France 98 · pens
-  **England** 1 – 0 **Argentina**  2002 · Beckham pen
-  **Argentina** 2 – 3 **England**  2005 friendly · Owen

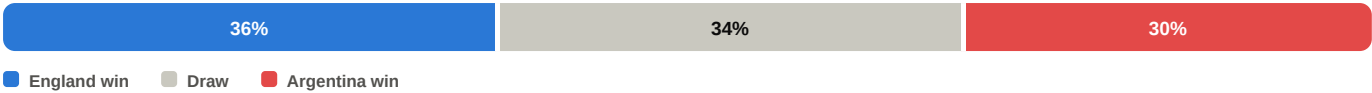
TOMORROW: THE SF2 VERDICT — THEN THIRD PLACE SATURDAY, THE FINAL SUNDAY



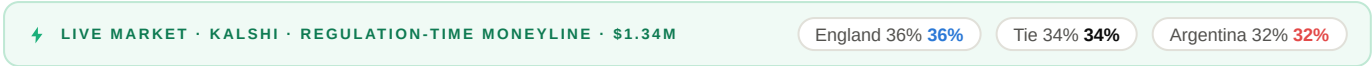
England v Argentina

★ OUR CALL: ENGLAND 2-1

RESULT AFTER 90 MINUTES



TO REACH THE FINAL



FORM

England have won every knockout round after falling behind — Bellingham has four knockout goals. Argentina have three straight extra-time escapes, and champions' habits die hard.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

First World Cup meeting since 2002, and the knockout ledger is even: 1966 and 2002 to England, 1986 and the 1998 shootout to Argentina. Every one of them left a scar.

FITNESS & FATIGUE

Dead even: both squads played 120 minutes on Saturday, both report clean bills of health, and Rice is fully over his quarter-final illness. Recovery, not fitness, is the variable.

WHERE THE MONEY IS

Kalshi's \$1.34m makes it the tightest market of the tournament: England 36, Tie 34, Argentina 32. A third of the money says ninety minutes won't settle it — again.

⚡ THE VERDICT

The narrowest call we've made. England's knockout resilience and the fresher attacking legs edge it: 2-1, with Bellingham involved again. But if Messi gets one clean look at destiny, everything flips.

The Crystal Ball is for family bragging rights only. Probabilities blend live prediction-market prices with our own reading of form, fitness and history. Entertainment — not financial or betting advice. Record so far: 5 winners from 8, two exact scorelines.



Lionel Messi

Plays tonight — one goal takes the outright lead

8



Kylian Mbappé

Blanked by Spain — one last chance in Saturday's third-place match

8



Erling Haaland

Eliminated — his race ended one goal short

7



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Mbappé's race is now limited to Saturday's third-place match; Messi and Kane still control their own destiny.

⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

0.26

France's expected goals last night — the lowest any team has managed against Spain's wall

2010

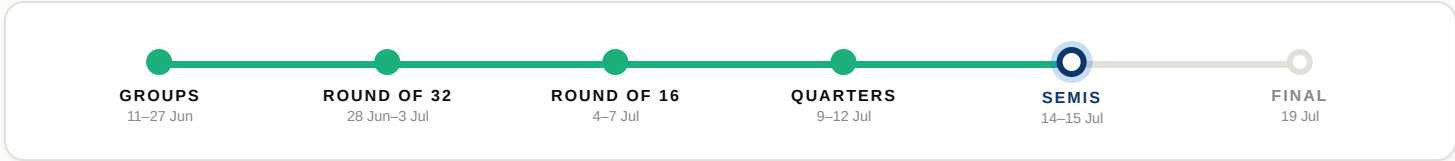
The last time Spain reached a World Cup final. They won it

72'

The minute France ran out of substitutes, still two goals down

\$1.3m

Traded on tonight's England–Argentina market on Kalshi by this morning



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

